

THE FEMALE GAMING EXPERIENCE ACROSS DIFFERENT CULTURES

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Abstract

This undergraduate thesis examines the female gaming experience in competitive first-person shooter (FPS) games across different cultures and geolocations. The study addresses the impact of different servers (Asian, Chinese, and North American) on the treatment of female gamers and explores how local cultural norms influence their gaming experiences. The research aims to provide insights into the "universal" female gaming experience, stereotypes and tropes associated with female gamers, and the historical and cultural factors that have shaped these perceptions.

The thesis employs a mixed-methods approach, combining immersive research methods with modern technology and social media, as well as conducting in-person interviews with female gamers of various ranks. Livestreaming gameplay and sharing it on social media platforms will allow for real-time audience engagement and feedback. The study draws inspiration from artistic experiments that utilized social media to gauge audience reactions and reflections.

By examining the intersection of culture, geolocation, and competitive gaming, this thesis aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of the treatment of female gamers. The findings will shed light on the challenges and experiences faced by female gamers in different cultural contexts and provide valuable insights into the evolving landscape of competitive gaming.

Keywords: Female Gaming, Video Games, Sexism in Media, Esports, Cross-culture

1. Introduction

Bright pink cat-ear headphones, a Japanese schoolgirl aesthetic, and a high-pitched voice sounding like a young kid are often associated with the term "girl gamer." While this portrayal does not accurately represent the diversity of female gamers in real life, it undeniably influences the experiences and challenges they encounter when playing their favorite games. I aim to investigate the female gaming experience and its variations across different cultures, focusing specifically on the impact of different servers (Asian, Chinese, North American) in competitive first-person shooter games. More specifically, within the context of Valorant, a competitive first-person shooter that came out in 2020. Furthermore, I will explore how the local culture of specific geolocations influences the treatment of female gamers in these games. To address these research questions, it is crucial to first examine the "universal" female gaming experience, the prevailing perceptions of female gamers, and the origins of stereotypes and tropes associated with them.

The female gaming experience is a subject of growing importance, as the gaming industry continues to expand and diversify. Despite the increasing number of women engaging in gaming and game development they often face unique challenges and biases within gaming communities. We can gain valuable insights into the complex dynamics at play by investigating the cultural nuances and regional differences that shape the female gaming experience. By focusing on competitive first-person shooter games, a genre known for its competitive nature and often male-dominated player base, and by examining the experiences of female gamers across different servers, we can identify similarities and differences in their treatment, highlighting the role of cultural influences in shaping these dynamics.

2. Literature Review

To achieve the objectives of this research, a comprehensive analysis of existing literature, scholarly articles, and relevant empirical studies were conducted on female gaming stereotypes and the general overall experience.

Historical Context

To begin with a brief overview of the history of video games and examining the influence of character designs and media on the female gaming experience, video games have often been criticized for featuring hyper-sexualized female characters clad in revealing attire and engaging in provocative movements and behaviors during gameplay. The design of these characters is typically influenced by the socio-cultural context in which game developers operate. These contexts give rise to gender norms and attitudes that shape the broader value systems prevalent in the social, cultural, political, and economic environments in which game developers create and market their products (Tompkins 2016). Essentially, game developers not only potentially convey socio-cultural values about gender through design choices, but specific gender norms and attitudes from the developer's local culture could influence the design choices. These types of influences affect more than just a developer, but gamers as well.



Figure 1 - Bayonetta, from the game series Bayonetta (2009)¹

¹ Image from <https://www.trustedreviews.com/news/bayonetta-3-release-date-3370469>

Rather than attempting to generalize to an increasingly diverse industry, the findings in the historical context and norms are mainly focused to U.S. (referred to as Western) and Japanese & Chinese (as Eastern) console/computer games because these countries and platforms have historically dominated the global marketplace.

In Western video games, a prevalent form of sexism known as hostile sexism is often observed, depicting men as dominant over women. In the post-World War II era, women's roles in households and workplaces underwent significant changes, granting them a newfound status and power in society. Concerns regarding sex roles, marriage, and sexuality during this period were reflected in the emergence of the beautiful yet treacherous cinematic femme fatale archetype in film noir, mirroring societal reservations about women encroaching upon traditionally male-dominated domains in American society (Boozier 1999). As video games are a form of media, they too were influenced by Hollywood and cinema, resulting in the portrayal of Western female video game characters embodying this femme fatale element, perpetuating the notion that women employ their bodies to seduce and harm men. This hostility towards women and the depiction of women in Western games likely contribute to the hostile treatment of women in gaming environments, particularly in competitive games where male dominance is prominent and perceived threats may arise.

In contrast, Eastern games, with a particular emphasis on Japan due to its historical dominance in the industry, often exhibit a form of benevolent sexism. Tompkins describes this as a phenomenon that "justifies patriarchy and attributes agentic qualities such as protectiveness, responsibility, and leadership to men, framing women as passive beneficiaries of men's actions" (2016). Hence, men are portrayed as protectors and women as weak and in need of assistance. Japanese media and cinema also play a role in shaping the portrayal of women in video games. The kawaii or cute aesthetic prevalent in anime and cinema has heavily influenced the character designs of Japanese female characters. The term "kawaii" was birthed in a novel in the 11th century describing women as docile beings. Etymologically, the word itself contains roots of a shy, blushing, appearance. Since Japan is a neighbor to China, and they share similar cultural values and more importantly media, this may explain why the stereotype of female gamers in

China reflects the perception that "males are strong and capable, while females are passive and obedient" (Hao 2022). Hao's study indicates that the general stereotype of female gamers in China revolves around their perceived weak gaming abilities (also observed in Western views of women) and their limited team awareness and dependence on others. These characteristics align with the impact of benevolent sexism.

The historical and cultural backgrounds of female game characters and the stereotypes associated with female gamers lead to the belief that there exist differences in the female gaming experience across various cultures, locations, and languages. While existing studies primarily focus on the relationship between the female experience in general and men and game characters, I aim to further investigate how these historical and cultural contexts influence the female gaming experience and how these experiences differ between cultures.

The Universal Female Gaming Experience

This research is mainly focused on the female experience in the realm of competitive games/gaming. Competitive games refer to multiple games where two teams of five people play against each other in a ranked match. Skill rating in these games is a rank that is given not just for time played, but for performance. Ranking a higher skill rating shows that you have more ability than others and is a source of social capital means (Khandaker 2019). Having an exceptionally high ranking can open the doors for more opportunities whether it is becoming a professional e-sports gamer being a person who people want to watch through streaming, or even coaching others. Ranking also serves as a part of identity for a gamer with it normally being the second question asked after finding out what particular game someone plays.

The gaming experience for female gamers is often marred by toxicity, lack of representation, and the struggle to be taken seriously within the gaming community. This section explores these challenges faced by female gamers, shedding light on the negative impact that they have on their participation and engagement. By examining the prevalence of toxicity, and the perception of female gamers being boosted rather than skilled, we can see how serious these problems are for upcoming females in the industry whether it is to be a professional esports gamer or other gaming careers.

Toxicity is a pervasive issue in any online environment, gaming environments are included. The anonymity that comes with being online, leads to a safer environment for those to express negative behaviors. With online gaming, these behaviors are becoming distressingly common including trash-talking, griefing, and sexual harassment. Trash-talking, while sometimes used positively to establish rapport among players, disproportionately targets female gamers, who are three times more likely to receive negative trash-talk than their male counterparts (Khandaker, 2019). Griefing is another form of toxicity common in online games and often refers to the intentional act of hindering another's enjoyment of playing a game. Griefing includes the common practice of "throwing" matches, where a person intentionally plays poorly or doesn't participate at all, which affects the whole team and in ranked matches causing them to de-rank (Khandakaer, 2019). Some people throw matches after hearing there is a female on the team which can affect the social capital and identity of the female gamer. This toxic environment hinders the learning, growth, and overall experience of female gamers, making it difficult for them to thrive or even make mistakes. Many female gamers, turn to Twitch to livestream their gameplay and make a career out of it, but the toxicity of the eSports community on Twitch is notorious (Procter, 2015), particularly for how women are treated, both when they win and lose, but especially if they fail or make mistakes.

Female gamers who achieve high ranks in competitive gaming often face the perception that they did not reach those levels through their skills but rather through being boosted. Boosting refers to the act of another player playing on an individual's account or playing alongside them to help them achieve higher ranks without significant effort on their part. This perception undermines the achievements of female gamers and diminishes their skills, perpetuating the stereotype that women are not capable of excelling in gaming on their merit.

Despite females constituting nearly half of the gaming population, game companies and professional esports organizations have only recently begun to actively promote women's products and support women gamers. This lack of representation is not limited to a specific culture or geographic location; it persists globally. The underrepresentation of women in the

gaming industry reinforces the perception that gaming is primarily for men, further marginalizing female gamers and inhibiting their sense of belonging and recognition.



This is a post from a highly reputable gaming keyboard manufacturer that had a giveaway in which four male winners could win the keyboard. Following the event the CEO followed with a post asking, “How is giving keyboards to males different from beauty bloggers giving lipsticks to women?”.

3. Related Art & Practice

Social media has been a powerful tool in both experiments and artistic expression. Using the artist Amalia Ulman as an example, she used social media as the main medium for her art project and conducted a small social experiment through it. She documented a fictional descent into a mental breakdown through her Instagram account, using her real persona to blur the line between reality and fiction. To make the experiment even more realistic, she ensured that she was mainly isolated for the months during the experiment so there would be no contradiction between her real life and online persona.

Another artist, Zou Yaqi lived off of the surplus of the wealthy for 21 days in Beijing without spending a penny. She researched socialites’ behaviors, apparel, and other related elements. Then by both using confidence and her newly equipped knowledge, she began her

undercover social experiment, later posting on her social media the findings. Both of these art pieces utilized social media to gauge audience reactions and reflections, which is something I plan to incorporate into my study as well.

4. Methodology

To gain further insights into the experiences of female gamers, this research project employs two distinct yet complementary methodologies, forming a foundation for an immersive exploration of the female gaming experience in an increasingly digitalized world. The first methodology integrates modern technology and social media platforms, combining live streaming, gameplay recording, and social media sharing. This multifaceted approach allows for a comprehensive examination of the topic, providing a firsthand experience and exposure to the unique gaming environment from a female perspective.

Livestreaming gameplay and sharing clips on social media serve as essential components of this research methodology. The initial upload of gameplay and clips on social media platforms is crucial for attracting and sustaining an audience for subsequent live streams. These bite-sized glimpses into the gaming process not only generate interest but also serve as a means to funnel potential viewers to the live streams, enabling real-time observation of audience reactions.

Livestreams facilitate a two-way interaction between the streamer and the audience, allowing for engagement through comments, likes, gift-giving, and questions. This interactive environment fosters a sense of community within the stream and provides valuable real-time feedback and engagement for the analysis of the research topic. Additionally, uploading clips to various social media platforms enables the collection and analysis of audience responses and reactions to gameplay, even after its occurrence.

The utilization of social media as a research tool finds precedent in the fields of experimentation and artistic expression. Artists mentioned before Amalia Ulman and Zou Yaqi have employed

social media platforms to gauge audience reactions and reflections. Ulman's art project involved documenting a fictional descent into a mental breakdown through her Instagram account, blurring the line between reality and fiction. Similarly, Zou Yaqi conducted an undercover social experiment, living off the surplus of the wealthy in Beijing for 21 days and sharing her findings on social media. Incorporating elements from these artistic endeavors, this study aims to leverage social media platforms to gauge audience responses and reflections within the gaming context.

In parallel with the live streaming and social media accounts, the research project will establish an online persona and build a community through various social media platforms, similar to Ulman's social media breakdown piece. This approach expands the global reach of the study, tapping into international perspectives and enhancing the analysis of the female gaming experience. By utilizing platforms such as YouTube, YouTube Shorts, TikTok, and Twitch for livestreaming and content uploads, the research project can engage with audiences from different countries across the world. Furthermore, considering China's unique digital ecosystem, as it contains its own social media servers and clouds, the study will actively engage with Chinese social media platforms, including Douyin and Bilibili, and livestreaming on Douyin.

To gain comprehensive insights into the female gaming experience, the research project will navigate and play through different servers, including North American, Chinese, and Asian servers. By engaging across these servers and playing at varying ranks, the study aims to discern whether these factors shape or alter the female gaming experience in discernible ways. This approach allows for a comprehensive understanding of female gamers' experiences and the identification of disparities across diverse geolocations and servers.

The second methodology employed in this research involves conducting in-person interviews with female players of various ranks. These interviews will provide deeper insights into their gaming experiences, capturing different perspectives and unique experiences linked to specific contexts. The emphasis on culture and geolocation arises from the recognition that local cultures profoundly influence individuals' worldviews. Considering the evolving nature of different servers, it is crucial to consider these factors in the research, particularly regarding language semantics and the game's development, as they significantly impact the treatment of females and

shape their gaming experiences. Additionally, conducting interviews takes away specific nuances and biases that might affect the research by my looks and nationality affecting my gameplay or the perception of me. Instead it creates a wider world view on the female gaming experience without the bias of one specific player.

The primary focus of this research project remains within the realm of competitive gaming, particularly first-person shooter (FPS) games. The first methodology will be implemented within the context of Valorant, an FPS game that has gained substantial popularity since its release in 2020. The recent launch of Chinese servers in July 2023 and the conclusion of the main Chinese Valorant competition (November 2023) provide an opportune time to research the topic surrounding the game. The unique timing and heightened interest make Valorant an excellent FPS case study for this research.

By delving into these specific aspects, this research project aims to unravel the intricate dynamics between cultural influences, geolocation, and their impact on the female gaming experience. This comprehensive exploration will contribute to a deeper understanding of how these factors intersect and shape the treatment of female players in the competitive gaming landscape.

5. Discussion / Research Findings / Analysis

E-Girl Aesthetic

In contemporary gaming culture, the image of the female gamer has been shaped by various stereotypes and aesthetic trends. One prominent example is the emergence of the "e-girl" aesthetic, which portrays female gamers as individuals who wear revealing attire and cater to the male gaze. The e-girl aesthetic, as defined by Law (2023), portrays female gamers as individuals who wear low-cut t-shirts and emphasize their breasts to appeal to the male gaze. Law argues that this aesthetic not only fails to empower women within the gaming community but also capitalizes on the fetishization of women by men. The focus on appearance and sexualization overshadows the skills and contributions of female gamers, reinforcing harmful stereotypes and

making it more difficult for them to be recognized for their abilities. By reducing female gamers to objects of desire, the e-girl aesthetic perpetuates a culture that values their physical appearance over their gaming prowess.

In contrast, the popularity of the e-girl aesthetic has inadvertently created a new avenue for marketing to female gamers. With female gamers accounting for nearly half of the gaming population, their growing influence has led to increased spending and the emergence of niche brands targeting this demographic. The vibrant gaming fashion associated with the e-girl aesthetic, such as pink headphones and colorful home gaming setups, has attracted more women to gaming, consequently expanding the market and diversifying the gaming community. This shift challenges the notion that female gamers are solely defined by their appearance, highlighting their agency as consumers and contributors to the gaming industry.

Beyond the aesthetic realm, gender stereotypes also manifest in the roles female gamers are expected to play within competitive gaming. Games like Valorant and Overwatch often feature characters known as "healers," which are predominantly associated with female players. These roles are not only characterized by their nurturing nature but are also perceived as the easiest to play. The term "Pocket Sage" emerged from Valorant, referring to a healer who exclusively supports a specific male player on the team, reinforcing the stereotype that women are only capable of fulfilling supportive roles. Khandakaer's (2019) interview with a high-ranking female Overwatch player highlights the conflict faced by women who enjoy playing support roles but also wish to challenge these stereotypes. The pressure to conform to expectations or defy them creates a dilemma that can detract from the enjoyment of the game, solely based on the player's gender.

6. Conclusion & Future Work

In conclusion, this paper delves into the female gaming experience in competitive first-person shooter games across different cultures and geolocations. By examining the impact of different servers and local cultural norms, the study aims to provide insights into the "universal" female gaming experience vs local one, the stereotypes associated with female gamers, and the historical and cultural factors that have shaped these perceptions. The methodology for research employs a mixed-methods approach, combining immersive modern technology and social media, as well as conducting in-person interviews with female gamers of various ranks. Through livestreaming gameplay, sharing it on social media, and engaging with audiences in real time, the study seeks to shed light on the challenges and experiences faced by female gamers in different cultural contexts and contribute to a deeper understanding of the evolving landscape of competitive gaming.

The findings of this research project highlight the significant impact of culture, geolocation, and competitive gaming on the treatment of female gamers. The historical and cultural backgrounds of female game character representations, as well as the prevailing stereotypes associated with female gamers, shape the experiences and challenges faced by women in gaming communities. The prevalence of toxicity, the perception of female gamers being boosted rather than skilled, and the lack of representation in the gaming industry all contribute to the marginalization of female gamers. By exploring these issues within the context of competitive first-person shooter games and examining the experiences of female gamers across different servers and cultural contexts, this thesis provides valuable insights into the complex dynamics at play and contributes to a deeper understanding of the treatment of women in gaming.

This project introduces innovative methodologies to gain a comprehensive understanding of the female gaming experience. By leveraging modern technology and social media platforms, such as livestreaming gameplay and sharing clips, the study creates an immersive environment that allows for real-time audience engagement and feedback. Drawing inspiration from artistic experiments that utilized social media to gauge audience reactions, the research project taps into international perspectives and builds a global community to enhance the analysis of the female gaming experience. Additionally, conducting in-person interviews with female players of various ranks provides deeper insights into their unique experiences and perspectives, capturing the influence of culture and geolocation on their gaming experiences.

Overall, this undergraduate thesis contributes to a deeper understanding of the treatment of female gamers in competitive first-person shooter games across different cultures and geolocations. By examining the intersection of culture, geolocation, and competitive gaming, the study sheds light on the challenges and experiences faced by female gamers, highlights the role of cultural influences in shaping these dynamics, and provides valuable insights into the evolving landscape of competitive gaming. The findings of this research project have implications for promoting inclusivity and diversity in the gaming industry and fostering a more welcoming and supportive environment for female gamers.

For future work, these research methods and information will be combined to have an impactful art piece that will contribute to the world of gaming for females.

Appendix

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